the demands for a caste census picked up. Later that year, the Maharashtra State Commission for Backward Classes (MSCBC) submitted a proposal to the state government on a caste census exercise, costing around Rs 435 crore. However, in March 2022, the state government set up a commission under former chief secretary J.K. Banthia to collect empirical data on the backwardness of OBCs. The commission estimated the OBC population at 37 per cent and the report was accepted by the SC in July 2022. The MSCBC's interim report had earlier estimated the share at 39 per cent. The Centre has refused to part with the 2011 Socio Economic and Caste Census data. Incidentally, while the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi is now vociferously

THE CASTE CENSUS, IF CONDUCTED, WILL REVEAL THE STATUS, DEMOGRAPHIC AS WELL AS SOCIO-ECONOMIC, OF MICRO OBCs OR SMALLER COMMUNITIES LIKE THE DENOTIFIED TRIBES

demanding a caste census, the MSCBC's still-born proposal was submitted when the coalition was in power. "It's obvious that beyond paying lip service to this cause, no party wants to really challenge the status quo for obvious reasons," says a member of the MSCBC.

Incidentally, the demand has support from some Brahmin groups. Moreshwar Ghaisas 'Guruji', president, Bahubhashik Brahmin Adhiveshan, counters the settled view that Brahmins form just around 3 per cent of Maharashtra's population, and says the numbers could be much higher. He stressed that Brahmins across sub-castes must register themselves as just 'Brahmins' to make the community count.

Writer-activist Sanjay Sonawani says that the stated objective of annihilation of caste and the demand for a caste-based census run counter to each other. "How will the caste system be phased out (if a caste-based headcount is conducted)?" he asks. But a census, and the mutual animus it can unlock, is a hurdle that others feel must be crossed. ■



ANI

LINE OF CONTROL
Karnataka Rakshana Vedike supporters stage a protest against Maharashtra in Belagavi in December

states; both were asked to refrain from making claims or demands for territory until the Supreme Court decided on the matter. A joint panel of ministers and a committee under an IPS officer were also formed to monitor sensitive issues.

Meanwhile, in Maharashtra, former CM and Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) president Uddhav Thackeray was in no mood to let the matter lie, renewing his demand that the disputed areas be declared a Union territory (UT). Karnataka higher education minister C.N. Ashwath Narayan retorted by pointing out that Marathi speakers were not in a significant majority in Mumbai, adding that if new UTs were being discussed, the commercial capital of the country should figure on top of the list. This prompted a fresh round of sabre-rattling.

However, language activists are not enthused at the fresh resumption of hostilities and the resolutions passed by the two legislatures. "These resolutions will have no impact on the larger matrix of the border dispute when the issue is already in court," says MES leader Shubham Shelke. Meanwhile, Kannada activists in Belagavi like Ashok Chandargi point out that it is the MES that is trying to keep the issue alive by raking it up every December when the Karnataka assembly convenes in Belagavi for its winter session. Even last month, the MES insisted on holding its annual 'Maha Melava' convention in Belagavi as a mark of protest against the legislature session being held in the city, but the attempt was thwarted by the district administration. Chandargi, president of the Belagavi District Kannada Organisations Action Committee, says that the MES, whose political support has been waning in Belagavi over the past couple of decades, is trying to make it an election issue for its survival.

Shelke, in turn, attributes CM Bommai's aggression to the forthcoming assembly election. "They [BJP] have no issue to fall back on other than Kannada pride. In fact, I won't be surprised if the government escalates the matter further [before the elections]," he says.

Indeed, CM Bommai's aggression in seeking parts of Maharashtra—like Jath where Kannada speakers are the dominant community—for integration with Karnataka has surprised many. Speaking in the Karnataka assembly, Bommai said the border issue is a "settled matter from all angles", and that the state chief secretary's letter to Maharashtra—asking the western state to refrain from sending a ministerial delegation to Belagavi—was well within the proper protocol.

Sachin Kalyanshetti, the BJP MLA from Akkalkot in Solapur on the Maharashtra side, says the demands from villages in his constituency (to join Karnataka) were an attempt to get long-pending development projects on track while using the emotive language issue as a bargaining chip. "These areas have poor infrastructure. The roads are bad and the development backlog is huge," he explained. Kalyanshetti also pointed out that while 135 of 140 villages in his taluka were predominantly Kannada-speaking, a mere 11 villages had taken this position. Local villagers had also withdrawn their demand after the authorities intervened, he claims. ■